

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1063

By Helton-Haynes

A RESOLUTION to recognize William "Bill" F. Knowles, Hamilton County Clerk, on the occasion of his retirement.

WHEREAS, it is appropriate that the members of this General Assembly should honor those citizens who have performed with uncommon devotion and enthusiasm throughout their years of public service; and

WHEREAS, one such estimable person is Bill Knowles, who, having admirably served the citizens of Hamilton County as County Clerk since 1974, is taking a much-deserved retirement on August 31, 2026; and

WHEREAS, a native of Chattanooga, Mr. Knowles was born in the St. Elmo community and is one of six children born to the late Chattanooga Police Detective Claude Knowles and Rose Knowles; and

WHEREAS, before his career as a county clerk, Bill Knowles received an honorable discharge from the United States Army Reserve at the rank of Sergeant First Class; in 1978, he received an honorary Doctor of Laws degree from Trevecca Nazarene University, and he holds a Master Barber license; and

WHEREAS, first taking office as county clerk in 1974, Mr. Knowles was elected to his thirteenth term in 2022; he is the longest-serving elected official in Hamilton County history, serving for a total of fifty-two years; and

WHEREAS, in the early days of his service, Quarterly Court and County Council minutes were maintained by pen and a stenographer pad; however, Mr. Knowles promptly implemented audio recordings and led the transition to digital systems that computerized County Commission minutes and records, and these recordings are provided to local media and made available to county officials and the public after each meeting; and

WHEREAS, under his leadership, the Clerk's office has prioritized preserving Hamilton County history through research and digitizing Legislative Body records dating back to the county's early days; computerizing historical and current marriage records; and enabling library staff, genealogists, and the public to conduct research online; and

WHEREAS, throughout his tenure, Bill Knowles and a dedicated team of deputy clerks have continually evaluated and implemented innovations to better serve their community; in 1993, the Clerk contracted with the State and allowed Hamilton County motorists to receive replacement titles in his office; and

WHEREAS, in 2001, Mr. Knowles worked with the State to allow motorists to renew registrations by mail and eventually online, making Hamilton County the first county in the State to offer internet vehicle renewal; in 2004, he helped make it possible for residents to renew or replace Tennessee driver licenses through the Clerk's office. Each initiative helped reduce long lines and provide more options for the public in renewing tags, titles, and licenses; and

WHEREAS, with the help of Mr. Knowles and the Hamilton County Clerk's Office, these innovations paved the way for statewide adoption of tags by mail and internet in all ninety-five counties; in addition to this progress and the construction of satellite tag and title facilities funded by the Mayor and County Commission, the Clerk's office was able to help motorists avoid traffic and congestion around the downtown courthouse; and

WHEREAS, most recently, Bill Knowles partnered with Food City to install self-service tag renewal kiosks throughout the county, which helped expand convenient renewal options for Hamilton County residents; and

WHEREAS, another successful initiative under Mr. Knowles's leadership was the identification and registration of semi-trailer fleets for companies with offices or depots in the county, an endeavor that helped generate millions of dollars in additional state and local revenue; and

WHEREAS, a leader in his profession, Bill Knowles has been entrusted with accounting for millions of dollars in State and county funds, and the Clerk's office consistently receives positive audit reports; and

WHEREAS, over the years, Mr. Knowles has received many recognitions, including a citizenship award from the Civitan Club and a Distinguished Alumni award from Chattanooga's Central High School, and his innovations have been recognized by the National Association of Counties on numerous occasions; he has been selected as County Clerk of the Year three times and was voted Outstanding Official of the Year by the County Officials Association; and

WHEREAS, Bill Knowles has also served in other ways that have benefited his community, including as a member of the Salvation Army Board of Directors, the Public Bible School Committee, the Advancing the Ministry of the Gospel Board of Directors, and the Convention and Visitors Bureau Board; he has served as president of the Tennessee County Officials Association, president of the Association of County Clerks, and founding member of the County Clerk's Organ Donor Awareness Program; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Knowles's philosophy of government, deep institutional knowledge, and openness to responsible change have elevated public service in Hamilton County, benefited taxpayers, and positively impacted not only those within his county but all Tennesseans; and

WHEREAS, he has been married to Marlene Coulter Knowles for seventy years, with whom he shares three grown children, Reba, Finley, and Alan; eight grandchildren; and five great-grandchildren; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Knowles and his wife are devoted members of Ridgedale Baptist Church in Chattanooga; and

WHEREAS, Bill Knowles exemplifies the spirit and allegiance to family and community that are characteristic of a true Tennessean; and

WHEREAS, throughout his illustrious tenure as Hamilton County Clerk, Bill Knowles has distinguished himself as a public-spirited citizen of the highest order, winning the respect and admiration of his colleagues and the people he has so ably served; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we extend to William "Bill" F. Knowles, Hamilton County Clerk, our heartfelt wishes for a happy and fulfilling retirement and every continued success in his future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.